Employee Handbook

Northstar Services Ltd

Training document for Week 9 - Document Automation and RAG.
This handbook is fictional and is designed only for automation practice. The policies below are not legal advice and do not represent a real employer.

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1. Working Hours and Flexible Working

Standard hours

The standard working week is 37.5 hours, normally worked Monday to Friday. Core collaboration hours are 10:00 to 16:00. Teams may agree different start and finish times provided service coverage is maintained and the employee's manager has approved the arrangement.

Flexible working

Employees may request a regular change to their working pattern after completing 12 weeks of service. A request should state the proposed working pattern, the preferred start date, and any likely impact on the team. Managers should normally respond within 21 calendar days.

Overtime

Overtime must be approved in advance. Employees should not assume that additional hours will be paid or converted into time off unless the arrangement has been confirmed by their manager before the work is performed.

2. Annual Leave

Entitlement

Full-time employees receive 25 days of paid annual leave per holiday year, in addition to UK public holidays. Part-time employees receive a pro-rated entitlement based on their contracted working days.

Booking leave

Annual leave requests should normally be submitted at least 10 calendar days before the first day of leave. Managers may decline or propose alternative dates where several team members request the same period or where essential service coverage would be affected.

Carry-over

Employees may carry over up to 5 unused annual leave days into the next holiday year with manager approval. Any carried-over days should normally be used by 31 March of the following year. Additional carry-over may be permitted where statutory rights apply or where long-term sickness or family leave prevented the employee from taking leave.

3. Parental Leave

Maternity, adoption and partner leave

Employees should notify People Operations as early as reasonably possible when they expect to take maternity, adoption or partner leave. Statutory eligibility and pay depend on individual circumstances and current legislation, so People Operations will confirm the applicable entitlement in writing.

Unpaid parental leave

Employees with at least one year of continuous service may request up to 18 weeks of unpaid parental leave for each eligible child. Unless otherwise agreed, no more than 4 weeks may be taken for a child in a single year. Requests should normally be made at least 21 calendar days in advance.

Returning to work

Before returning from an extended period of family leave, employees may request a discussion about phased return, temporary changes in working hours, or other reasonable adjustments. Any temporary arrangement should be documented with a start date and review date.

4. Sickness and Medical Appointments

Reporting sickness

If an employee is unable to work because of illness, they should notify their manager as soon as possible and normally before 09:30 on the first day of absence. The employee should provide an expected return date if known and keep the manager updated if the absence continues.

Evidence

For sickness lasting seven calendar days or fewer, employees may self-certify. For longer absences, appropriate medical evidence may be required in line with applicable rules.

Medical appointments

Where practical, routine medical appointments should be arranged outside core working hours. Managers may approve reasonable paid time for unavoidable appointments, particularly where rescheduling would cause significant delay.

5. Remote Working

Regular remote working

Employees may work remotely for up to three days per week where their role and team arrangements permit. The normal expectation is that employees attend their contractual office or agreed workplace for at least two days each week unless a different arrangement has been formally approved.

Working abroad

Employees must not work from another country without prior written approval from People Operations and their department head. Requests should be submitted before travel because tax, immigration, information-security and insurance issues may apply.

Workspace

Employees working remotely are responsible for maintaining a suitable working environment and protecting confidential information from unauthorised access.

6. Expenses and Business Travel

General rule

Reasonable business expenses will be reimbursed when they are necessary for work, supported by appropriate evidence, and submitted within 30 calendar days of the expense date.

Meals

When travelling on approved business away from the normal workplace, employees may claim reasonable meal costs up to GBP 35 per day. Alcohol is not normally reimbursable unless it forms part of an approved client-hosting event.

Travel

Rail travel should normally be booked in standard class. Air travel should normally be economy class for flights under six hours. Exceptions require approval from the relevant department head before booking.

7. Information Security

Passwords and accounts

Employees must use unique passwords for company systems and must not share authentication credentials. Multi-factor authentication must be enabled where the company system supports it.

Company information

Confidential company information must only be stored in approved systems. Employees must not upload confidential documents to personal cloud-storage accounts or unapproved AI services.

Security incidents

Suspected phishing, lost devices, accidental disclosure or other security incidents should be reported to the IT or Security team immediately. Employees should not delay reporting while attempting to investigate the incident themselves.

8. Performance and Training

Performance discussions

Managers should hold regular performance discussions with employees. These conversations should cover priorities, progress, blockers, development goals and support required.

Training budget

Employees may request up to GBP 750 per calendar year for role-relevant professional training, courses or certifications. Training must be approved before purchase. Unused training budget does not carry over into the following year.

Mandatory training

Security, data-protection and other mandatory training assigned by the company must be completed by the stated deadline.

End of training handbook. Suggested RAG test questions include: "How many days of annual leave do I get?", "Can I work from another country?", "How much can I spend on meals when travelling?", and "How much unpaid parental leave is available?"